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Presidential Telephone Calls - Memorandum of Conversations 5/3/91 - 7/21/91

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NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20506

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telcon with Cesar Gaviria Trujillo, President
of Colombia, June 20, 1991

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Cesar Gaviria Trujillo, President
Notetaker: R. Rand Beers

DATE, TIME June 20, 1991, 5:13 - 5:18 P.M. EST
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

The President returned a telephone call from President Gaviria concerning the surrender of Pablo Escobar. President Gaviria spoke in English. (U)

The President: Hello, Mr. President. How are you? (U)

President Gaviria: Hello, how are you? (U)

The President: Just fine. I am delighted to hear from you. (U)

President Gaviria: I was calling to tell you about Escobar. (U)

The President: We keep on having the line cut out. Can you hear me now? (U)

President Gaviria: Yes. (U)

The President: Now, that is a little better. (U)

President Gaviria: I wanted to tell you about the surrender of Escobar. It was a victory of law and our joint effort. He surrendered yesterday. He was transported by helicopter to the jail. Upon arrival, the judicial process opened against him. (U)

About the jail, we have set it up to avoid him from being able to escape. It is also a big jail. The press has reported that it is a luxurious jail. That is not true. It's not luxurious. You can verify that, it's no better than any other. We will be taking all measures to keep him in jail, to see that we avoid complications, including monitoring his communications. (U)

[President Gaviria's voice fades out again.]

The President: Hello? This connection is bad. But I think I heard all that. Go ahead. (U)

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President Gaviria: We have a new judicial process which uses anonymous and protected judges. We have a good case against him, with lots of evidence. I hope we can agree on cooperating. It should all work well. (S)

The President: I know you talked to Bob Martinez. (C)

President Gaviria: Yes. We talked yesterday. (C)

The President: He filled me in. That seems to answer some of our concerns. But, the press seems to make the jail look like a country club. (S)

President Gaviria: No, just ask the Embassy; they can verify. It's only a jail, no more. (S)

The President: OK. Look, if there is any cooperating we can help with, let us know. I know we have our differences on extradition. We have been open about this, that we have not agreed with that option. But, if there is any evidence in the trial that can be helpful, we be glad to do it. We have lots of cases here. Maybe we can cooperate on the evidence here. (S)

President Gaviria: That would be very very good. (C)

The President: Good. We understand the problems you have. We would have preferred extradition. But, I know you are under a lot of pressure. If extradition is not an option, I think they can convict him, based on the evidence reported against him, and hope they give him a long prison term. He is a really bad egg, and the Colombian people know this too. What about this priest, who seems almost like a campaign manager for him? What is the word about the priest? (S)

President Gaviria: The Colombian Government got [not heard] from the National Assembly. We really can build a strong case here. And, we will work very hard against the Cali Cartel. (S)

The President: Good, very good. We will continue to work with you. We have our differences, but we want to cooperate anyway we can. I appreciate your phone call. I hope we can keep up the pressure. The best thing we can hope for is a fair trial and a just sentence. I know you can't control all that, but that would go a long way. Good talking to you. (S)

President Gaviria: Yes. (U)

The President: How is your family. Is it OK? (U)

President Gaviria: Yes. Thank you. (U)

The President: Give them my love. (U)

President Gaviria: OK, thank you. Bye bye. ()

-- End of Conversation --

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